

מען דארף קענען די מלאכה

The Act of Fundraising Through the Lens of the 39 Melachos

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ILLUSTRATIONS BY MRS. ANNITA SOBLE

Fundraising, defined for the purpose of this article as facilitating one's fellow to give tzedoka, plays a significant role in our day to day lives as shluchim. When viewed through the prism of the 39 Melachos, fundraising takes on new meaning. Below please find a sampling ותן לחכם ויחכם עוד.

First, a caveat: The definition of a melocho is an act that involves מחשבת מלאכה, an action done properly and with deliberate intent. A melocho done כלאחר יד, in a backhanded manner, is simply not a melocho. Fundraising can be defined in the same way. Facilitating the supreme mitzvah of tzedoka requires focus and proper intent, with the esteem that this endeavor deserves.

Tie the Knot

There is really only one real knot: קשר של קיימא. If you are going out there, fundraising for a mosad with the Rebbe's name, there are no shortcuts. Strengthen your keshar with the meshaleyach so that it is continuously a קשר של קיימא.

Light the Spark

As lamplighters, our task is to illuminate the lives of others (מבעיר). Recognize and appreciate the myriad people and places you may never encounter without your constant need to fundraise, and the invaluable opportunities to spread light that each one brings. Fundraising is not only the means to an end; it is a most precious end to itself.

Eliminate by Illuminating

Sometimes just erasing (מחוק) preconceived notions about who you are and what you do is what's needed to get you on track for a charitable gift or a long term donor relationship. This is especially true with a shliach who shows up in town looking different than anything the baal habos has ever seen. The baal habos does not know what makes the shliach different from "the guys throwing rocks in Meah She'arim." Sometimes, just a brief meeting where he can be exposed to Chabad can eliminate the impediment to the gift (סותר על מנת לבנות).



Focus on the Task at Hand

Chassidus is replete with discussion on the pros and potential of the Nefesh haBahamis, a creature of unrestrained energy. עבודה עם עצמו, or עיבוד עורות, in the parlance of Hilchos Shabbos, offers an essential principle in the life of a fundraiser shliach. All the passion in the world is worth little without the disciplined restraint of hard work. Practicing self discipline—checking emails at careful intervals, staying focused on individual tasks until they are completed—is essential to curing the “עבדא בהפקירא ניהא ליה” syndrome.

Cultivate Spiritually

A running theme in Igeres HaKodesh of Tanya (which in many ways can be described as a direct solicitation to support the destitute Yidden of Eretz Yisroel) is זורע צדקות מצמיח ישועות. The Rebbe would often quote the Friediker Rebbe’s instructions to the shadarim: זיי רוחניות און קלייב גשמיות, sow ruchniyus and reap gashmiyus. And, as the Rebbe adds in Igros Kodesh, one is dependent on the other. Beyond simply the zechus we present to a donor, it’s imperative that a shliach come prepared with a small vort, a spiritual seed, together with the material request.



Create a Plan

Business people respect a plan. Rather than asking for a lump sum or general request, disentangle (מנפק) the nature of your activities and itemize the exact amount of money you need for each area of your budget. Have a plan. It will clarify things for you and earn the trust of those who support your mosad.

Build Trust

Most people don’t win the lottery and it’s highly unusual for anyone to receive a very large first-time charitable gift. There’s a good reason for this: savvy donors typically test the organization with smaller “test gifts” before giving anything substantial for an annual or capital campaign. Never overlook the \$18 check; it may just be the first step in בונה, building trust and moving toward a future relationship.



Deep Sea Pearls or Pearl Barley?

Many of the melochos involved in producing bread (דש, זורה) call for separating the wheat from the chaff (בורר). In the world of fundraising on shlichus, this is relevant on so many levels. Whom to call, whom not to call, who requires a long follow-up conversation and who should best be left off the list of solicitation calls—each of these are important questions to consider. As shluchim, all are welcome through our doors. But in direct solicitations, many of us have wished we had been told “no” on the first visit. Discerning potential givers from potential time-wasters is the עבודת הבידורים for a fundraising shliach with limited hours in the day. The more one is out there pounding the pavement, the easier it becomes to work the בורר process.

The בורר mindset also comes in handy when considering daily task and time management; we must select which items to place at the top of our lists and which are to be addressed later. The Rebbe was known to say that a shliach should focus on the deep sea pearls, not pearl barley.

(Parshas Chaye Sara, 5747, p. 93)

Acknowledge the Effort Involved in Transferring Funds

Interestingly, the Gemara in Meseches Shabbos begins with the melocha of הוצאה, though it is listed as the final melocho when all 39 are listed together. Tosfos addresses this anomaly and concludes that it is a melocho garua, a difficult melocho. A valuable lesson: When a donor is gracious enough to transfer his hard earned money from a רשות היחיד, his personal property, to the רשות הרבים, the benefit of the community—and from a רשות היחיד to the רשות הרבים of the יחידו של עולם, it is hard work. As fundraisers, we must always be cognizant of the challenges involved in this transfer, and the respect and gratitude we must feel toward someone who overcomes this test, even if he or she has what to give.





Don't Bank 'Til You Thank!

Write (כותב) the thank you letter. If appropriate, you can email it, too. Acknowledging the gift, the effort involved in giving it (see above, הוצאה) and its impact on your mosad, is the most essential piece of the entire fundraising process. Try the old fundraising adage, "Don't bank 'til you thank!"

Gather the Givers

Let your donors see each other. Though it involves lots of effort, a benefit dinner, luncheon, or parlor meeting provides something that a one-on-one meeting cannot: a show of force for your mosad. Even if there are only a few serious donors in the room, the show of support will most likely impress these individuals. מעמר. Bring the people together! You'll be glad you did.



The entire planting process is a mere כלי for possible success. Seeing the fruits of our efforts is not a matter of cause and effect, it is a "yogato" that sees a "motzoso" from above.

Thirty Nine Melochos are a long and arduous process. But, we are assured by our mishaleyach (HaYom Yom 25 Cheshvon), "אז מען אקערט און פארזייט, וואקסט," when you plow and you sow, things will grow. ❧

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ליובאוויטש

א'ספערן פארקוויי
ברוקלין, נ. י.

By the Grace of G-d
Rosh Chodesh Tammuz, 5734
Brooklyn, N.Y.

BROOKLYN
1974

Mr. I. I. Stone
200-11 N. Park Blvd.
Shaker Heights, O.

Greeting and Blessing:

I was pleased to receive your regards through Rabbi Moshe Kotlansky, together with your check, for which receipt is enclosed.

Needless to say, an unsolicited contribution towards our work for the cause of Torah and Mitzvot is a welcome encouragement and is sincerely appreciated.

It is an old Jewish custom to express some thoughts when the occasion presents itself. So I will avail myself of this opportunity in the confident hope - based on our personal acquaintance of long standing - that you will accept my remarks in the spirit in which they are made.

I do not have to tell you about the vital, world-wide activities of Lubavitch. Nor do I have to emphasize the obvious that these activities could not be carried on, in all their scope and ramifications, without the active financial support of friends who appreciate the vital importance of such work. I may add that the importance of the various activities is not necessarily proportionate to their funding, as sometimes a very vital activity requires a relative smaller expenditure. But, by and large, considering the global scope of all our activities, each requires very substantial funds.

Now, as a matter of policy, I refrain from making appeals for funds, and do not engage in fund-raising, for two reasons. Firstly, in order not to prejudice those Lubavitcher institutions which depend on fundraising. Secondly, because public-minded individuals who are familiar with our work do not usually require special prodding on my part, and each according to his means and modus operandi comes forward to take an appropriate share in our work. There are occasions when I make an exception, where special circumstances impel me - for the benefit of the individual concerned - to suggest to him a major role in certain of our activities, but such exceptions are relatively rare.

In light of the above, I have also refrained from mentioning financial matters to you, for the said two reasons. Firstly, because you are involved with Lubavitch work in your community, which, as I mentioned during our conversation, has priority. Secondly, because I consider you among those who require no prompting in this matter.

However, upon receiving your check, I had to take note of it vis-a-vis your role in our work. Let me assure you again that any contribution received, whether large or small, and whether or not it reflects the donor's real or potential effort, is a Zechus for the donor, since the money goes for the cause of Torah and Mitzvot; and it is gratefully and cheerfully accepted.

On the other hand, and this is something that is easier to present to a businessman, where, for example, a factory or business is not operating at full productivity, and where much more could be achieved without overloading capacity and overheads - it would not be right not to call attention to it, especially among friends. I would, therefore, be less than candid and fair if - while expressing appreciation for your donation, and assuring you that it will be used for the utmost good, which will stand you in good stead - I were not to mention that it does not measure up the great Zechus that ought to be yours by taking a share in our work that is more commensurate with your posture and role in Jewish life.

I trust that you will not consider this a disguised appeal for money, but for what it is - an objective evaluation, coming from a good friend, whose first and only motive is to look at the matter from the viewpoint of your best interests. At any rate, consider it as having read my thoughts.

I take this opportunity of expressing my pleasure at having heard from your daughter, who participated in the Convention of Nshel Chabad here, that you, too, were present later on. I was particularly gratified to hear from her about the progress of her children, your grandchildren, bless them. May they continue to advance from good to better and be a source of evergrowing Nachas, true Nachas, which is Torah Nachas, to their parents and grandparents.

With esteem and blessing,

M. Schneerson